OXFORD AGENTIC

The First Workflow Picker

How to choose the one task worth automating first - for founders, directors and senior leaders who already use AI daily

BY DRUMMOND GILBERT

ABOUT 15 MINUTES TO READ

BRING ONE REAL TASK FROM THIS WEEK

This guide is for senior people who already use AI daily, get good output from a chat window, and still do the same work by hand next week. You will leave with one task chosen and written down.

Most people start with the task that annoys them most. It is rarely the best first one.

The annoying task tends to be messy, rarely repeated, or full of judgement calls. It makes a poor first workflow, and when it goes badly people decide the tools are the problem. Pick well and the first workflow runs and you are in a better position to build the next one. Pick badly and it ends up in the drawer with the other things you meant to try.

This guide gives you a four-question scorecard, five worked examples, an honest list of what tends to break, and a one-page brief to write your task down. It makes no claims about what any tool can do for you. It helps you choose.

02	The scorecard	Page 3
03	Five worked examples	Page 4
04	What breaks, and how you would notice	Page 6
05	Your one-page brief	Page 7
06	If you would like to build it with other people	Page 8

Take one task you do by hand. Score each question 0, 1 or 2.

#	QUESTION	0	1	2	SCORE
1	**Does it come round on a schedule?**	Once in a while	Monthly	Weekly or more	☐
2	**Could you write the steps on one page?**	"It depends" every time	Mostly, with exceptions	Yes, a new starter could follow it	☐
3	**Can the inputs be reached?**	Lives in someone's head or on paper	Scattered across tools	Sits in a place a tool can read (a mailbox, a sheet, a folder)	☐
4	**If it goes wrong, how fast do you notice?**	Weeks later, and it costs money or trust	Within the week	Same day, and it is cheap to fix	☐

Add a fifth, pass or fail: would you miss the judgement?

If the value of the task is you deciding something - what to tell a client, who to hire, what to say to a worried colleague - leave it with you. Automate the work around the decision, not the decision.

READING YOUR SCORE

7-8

A good first workflow. Start here.

5-6

Workable, but tighten question 2 or 3 first. Write the steps down; move the inputs into one place.

0-4

Not a first pick. Park it.

Fail on the fifth

Keep it. That is a decision about where your time goes, not a gap in the tools.

How the scorecard reads on real tasks

These are illustrations of how to score, not results anyone has achieved.

8

OUT OF 8

1. The weekly report

Every Monday, someone pulls figures from a sheet, adds three lines of commentary and emails it round. Scheduled, steps are the same each week, the inputs sit in one place, and a wrong figure shows up when the first reader replies. A good first pick.

5

WITH A CONDITION

2. First-pass CV screening

Repeats whenever you hire (1), the criteria can be written down (2), CVs arrive in one inbox (2), but a miss is slow and costly to show - a good candidate quietly never reaches you (0). Workable only as a first sort that *you* review in full, never as a filter that decides. Check the rules on automated decisions about people (UK GDPR, Article 22) and on bias before you use anything like this.

7

OUT OF 8

3. The partner update

A monthly note to the same eight people, drawn from your notes and calendar. The steps are clear; the risk is tone. Let it draft; you read every one before it goes.

7

OUT OF 8

4. Meeting notes into actions

Happens every day (2), the steps are clear (2), the inputs are the transcript (2), and a missed action is noticed within the week (1). A sensible place to start.

6

OUT OF 8

5. The weekly newsletter

It comes round every week and the structure is fixed, but the value is in what you choose to say. Let a draft assemble the links and the first pass; the last 10% - the angle, the line that sounds like you - stays yours. Workable, with the edit written into the brief.

LEAVE ALONE

And one to leave alone: the performance conversation

Scores 1 on steps, 0 on cost of error, and fails the fifth question. Use a tool to gather the facts beforehand if you like. The conversation stays yours.

These are the ways a workflow goes wrong, whoever builds it.

It is worth knowing them before you start.

It looks right and is not.

Workflows fail quietly: the output is fluent and wrong.

HOW YOU WOULD NOTICE - read the first ten outputs in full, then spot-check one in five on a set day each week.

The inputs change.

A column is renamed, a mailbox rule moves.

HOW YOU WOULD NOTICE - have the workflow stop and tell you when an input is missing, rather than fill the gap.

The edge case nobody wrote down.

The one client with a different process.

HOW YOU WOULD NOTICE - give it a "not sure" outcome that comes to you, and read what lands there.

Permissions creep.

A workflow that can read your mailbox may be given permission to send from it as well.

HOW YOU WOULD CONSTRAIN IT - start read-only; give it write access only where you have a review step before anything leaves.

Nobody owns it.

It runs for six months and no one remembers what it does.

HOW YOU WOULD NOTICE - one name, one date, one line describing what "wrong" looks like.

05 - YOUR ONE-PAGE BRIEF

Write this for your best-scoring task. It takes about ten minutes, and it is a good brief to bring to a build day.

1 **The task, in one sentence.** e.g. "Turn Monday's sales sheet into the weekly update."

2 **What triggers it.** A time, an email, a form.

3 **The inputs, and where they live.**

4 **The steps, as you do them today.** Five at most.

5 **What the finished output looks like.** Attach a good example.

6 **Who checks it, and when.** Name a person.

7 **What "wrong" looks like.** Two examples.

8 **What it must never do.** Send without review, touch client data, delete anything.

If you can fill in all eight lines, you have a task worth building. If you get stuck on line 4 or line 7, that is useful too: it tells you the task is not ready, and you have lost ten minutes rather than a month.

Writing the brief is the easy half.

The Oxford Agentic Bootcamp is a one-day build in Oxford: you bring one real task like the one above, work through several build cycles with no block of more than about 25 minutes of talk, and leave with a workflow that runs.

Four to a table, capped, and part of the day is working out what to leave alone.

If that sounds useful, book your place here:

oxfordagentic.com/bootcamps/oxford-agentic-bootcamp

If not, you will get a few short notes from me over the next fortnight, and you can unsubscribe at any time.

Drummond

Oxford Agentic is independent and is not affiliated with the University of Oxford or any of its colleges.